

The Complete Malaysian Parent Guide

“I Think My Child Might Be Autistic. What Do I Do?”

Please read this first

This guide helps you take practical next steps. It does not replace a proper assessment by a licensed doctor or clinical psychologist. Use this guide to know where to go, what to ask, and how to protect your child.

You are not too late

Many children make meaningful progress with the right support, understanding, and early intervention. You do not have to figure everything out alone.

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SECTION 1

Signs to Watch For

The signs below are grouped into two areas based on DSM-5-TR criteria. Seeing these signs does not mean your child definitely has autism. It means a professional should take a closer look.

How to use this section

If your child shows signs from Area A and at least two groups from Area B, it is worth arranging a professional assessment.

Area A	How your child communicates and connects with others
A1 Back-and-forth communication	Does not respond to name, limited eye contact, rarely shares interests, does not copy others, difficulty with back-and-forth interaction.
A2 Body and face communication	Few gestures, facial expressions may not match, eye contact feels different, difficulty understanding body language.
A3 Friendships and play	Limited interest in peers, plays beside others without interaction, difficulty with pretend play or adapting socially.

Area B	Patterns of behaviour, interests, and senses
B1 Repetitive movements or speech	Flapping, rocking, spinning, repeating words or phrases, lining up toys, repeated actions.
B2 Need for sameness and routine	Very upset by small changes, rigid routines, difficulty accepting new ideas or transitions.
B3 Intense specific interests	Extremely focused on one topic or unusual object, much more knowledge than expected for age.
B4 Sensory differences	Covers ears, bothered by textures, seeks strong sensory input, fascinated by lights or patterns.

Source: DSM-5-TR, American Psychiatric Association, 2022. Signs must be present from early childhood, cause real difficulty in daily life, and cannot be better explained by another condition.

What to Do Next: Step-by-Step Plan

Step 1 - Go to Klinik Kesihatan

Walk in. No referral letter needed. Say: "I am concerned about my child's development. I would like to request a developmental screening." Bring your child, health booklet, notes, and videos.

Step 2 - Ask for a referral

Ask for a referral letter to see a Developmental Paediatrician at a government hospital. Government waiting times may be 3 to 18 months.

Step 3 - Start therapy while waiting

You do not need a diagnosis to start speech therapy. Early communication support can begin while waiting for assessment.

Step 4 - Document everything

Record short videos and keep dated notes. This helps doctors and therapists understand patterns faster.

Step 5 - Verify credentials

Ask private professionals for registration details and check their qualifications before committing.

You do not need to wait for a diagnosis to start helping your child

Support for communication, emotional regulation, daily routines, and learning can begin immediately.

SECTION 3

Government vs Private: What to Expect

Service	Government	Private
Autism assessment	Free or subsidised with referral	Estimated RM800 to RM3,000+
Waiting time	3 to 18 months depending on location	Usually 1 to 4 weeks
Speech therapy	Free with referral, waiting list likely	Estimated RM150 to RM400/session
Occupational therapy	Free with referral, waiting list likely	Estimated RM150 to RM350/session
Early intervention	Limited availability	Estimated RM1,500 to RM4,000/month
Diagnosis accepted?	Yes	Yes

What we recommend

Submit your government referral immediately. If possible, use private support while waiting. Do not delay starting therapy if your child needs communication, sensory, or developmental support.

SECTION 4

How to Choose a Therapist Safely

Ask clear questions before committing to any private therapist, centre, or programme.

Professional	What to check
Developmental Paediatrician	Medical registration and specialist training. Verify doctors through the Malaysian Medical Council.
Clinical Psychologist	Master's or PhD in Clinical Psychology. Ask for registration details.
Speech Therapist	Degree in Speech Sciences or Speech Pathology. Check professional registration and MASH where relevant.
Occupational Therapist	Degree in Occupational Therapy. Ask for MAHPC registration.
Behaviour Therapist / ABA	Ask if they are BCBA-certified or supervised by a BCBA. Avoid cure claims or pressure packages.

Stop and walk away if...

Someone claims to cure autism, refuses to explain qualifications, pressures you to pay large upfront packages, discourages formal assessment, or will not provide goals/progress updates.

Common Mistakes Parents Make

Waiting too long

Many families wait because they hope their child will “grow out of it.” Early support matters.

Delaying speech therapy

Communication support should begin as early as possible when there are concerns.

Comparing with relatives

Every child develops differently. Comparisons can delay practical support.

Trying random supplements first

Be cautious of anyone promising a “cure” for autism.

Waiting for school to solve everything

Children often need support both at school and at home.

Listening to fear-based advice online

Focus on evidence-based guidance from qualified professionals.

You are not failing as a parent

Many parents feel confused, overwhelmed, or uncertain in the beginning. Seeking support early is a strength.

Exactly What to Say

Situation	Script
At Klinik Kesihatan	"I am worried about my child's development. Can I request a developmental screening today?"
Asking for referral	"Can I have a referral letter to see a Developmental Paediatrician? I am worried my child might have autism."
At specialist appointment	"My child is [age]. I am concerned about [2 to 3 specific observations]. I have notes and videos I can show you."
Checking credentials	"Are you registered with the Malaysian Allied Health Professions Council? Can you give me your registration number?"
If dismissed	"I would like my concerns to be written in my child's medical file. Can we schedule a follow-up?"

SECTION 7

Organisations That Can Help in Malaysia

Organisation	What they do
NASOM	Early intervention, therapy, school support, and parent guidance.
MASH	Professional body for Speech Therapists in Malaysia.
OT Malaysia	Professional body for Occupational Therapists in Malaysia.
MAHPC	Government body registering allied health professionals.
MMC	Government body registering doctors in Malaysia.
JKM	OKU card, welfare support, community programmes.

Websites to save: nasom.org.my | mash.org.my | ot-malaysia.my | alliedhealth.moh.gov.my | mmc.gov.my | jkm.gov.my

SECTION 8

First Steps Checklist

- Go to nearest Klinik Kesihatan and request developmental screening.
- Bring health booklet, written notes, and short video clips.
- Ask for referral to Developmental Paediatrician.
- Submit referral to government hospital.
- Start speech therapy if there are communication concerns.
- Consider OT if there are sensory, daily living, or school readiness concerns.
- Create a phone folder for videos and notes.
- Ask private professionals for registration details.
- Avoid anyone promising a cure or pressuring you into large packages.

Free APC Parent Tool

The APC Calm Companion is a free mobile-friendly support tool designed to help parents during meltdowns, routines, transitions, sensory overwhelm, communication breakdowns, and difficult moments.

Open the free tool

<https://apc-calm-companion.pages.dev>

Save it to your phone so you can open it quickly like a normal app.

iPhone / iPad

- Open the tool in Safari.
- Tap the Share button.
- Scroll down and tap “Add to Home Screen”.
- Tap “Add”.

Android

- Open the tool in Chrome.
- Tap the 3-dot menu.
- Tap “Install app” or “Add to Home Screen”.
- Tap “Install” or “Add”.

Important

The APC Calm Companion is an educational support tool. It is not medical advice, diagnosis, therapy, or crisis support.

You do not have to figure everything out today.

The most important step is starting. The earlier families receive the right guidance, the more opportunities children have to build communication, emotional regulation, independence, and confidence.

Need more support?

Book a free 15-minute discovery call: <https://cal.com/autismpathwaysconsulting/free-discovery-call>

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For information only. Not medical advice. Sources: DSM-5-TR (APA 2022) | Allied Health Professions Act 774 (Malaysia 2016).